



PHOTOS BY **ARUN KUMAR**



FOR FINANCE MINISTER NIRMALA SITHARAMAN, presenting Union Budget 2024-25 was a Herculean task. From job creation to GDP growth, she had to manage the expectations of stakeholders after the recent General Elections. On top of that, she had to keep the two key allies of the NDA government—the JD(U) and the TDP—content. Both the states had demanded special status. Job creation, with a special focus on formalisation, took centre stage, and the Budget aimed to simplify tax rates. Maintaining a steady growth momentum was also on the agenda. Sitharaman, in her Budget speech, alluded to the ambition of Viksit Bharat (Developed India) by 2047 and this Budget worked to prepare a road map for that. Taking the Budget forward, industry leaders gathered under one roof to dissect it and provide deeper insights. Take a look at some highlights of the event. **BT**

BALANCING EXPECTATIONS

- (From left) **Sourav Majumdar**, Editor, *Business Today*
- **Siddharth Zarabi**, Managing Editor, *Business Today TV*
- **Nirmala Sitharaman**, Finance Minister
- **Rahul Kanwal**, News Director of India Today and Aaj Tak, and Executive Director of *Business Today*

» Responding to a question on whether export curbs are fair to farmers, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, at the India Today-Business Today Budget Round Table 2024, said export curbs on farm produce are not fair to farmers who are denied an opportunity to earn. She added that most governments struggle with achieving a balance between the interests of farmers and consumers

» The finance minister said, “I want to support the farmer. I don’t want unpredictable restrictions on exports. But if in our country, market prices go skyrocketing, the consumer equally approaches the government to ask, ‘What are you doing for me?’”

» Responding to a question on the suggestion in the Economic Survey to exclude food items from inflation, the FM said that the Survey is prepared by the Chief Economic Advisor, and his team and the finance ministry maintains an arm’s length from it. She added that it is a subject worthy of discussion

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